CHAPTER 48

INJURED ASHES

1 August –16 September 2019

It's the evening of Cooky's final Test and I'm waking up to find an empty dressing room: family, friends and players gone. I have missed the celebrations again – all the physical exertion and emotional exhaustion, my mind wanting nothing but a deep sleep. I come to, curled up on the corner of the bench in the dressing room at The Oval, whites still on, cap and jumper splayed out across the floor, my gear still everywhere but everyone else is gone. It's like I'm the last man to ever be in the England team. A vision comes to me of holding on to being an England player even when all the cricket is gone, still there saying, 'No, I'm not done yet, this isn't over.' I test out the words Cooky said to me at Trent Bridge. How would they feel coming out of my mouth? There is no part of them that fits, not one of them that feels like they are my own. I am not thinking about any particular legacy moment or number of wickets to hit. I am put on earth to do this, to see the ball do what it does and to turn batters into S shapes. I will play on.

It's 2019 and I am desperate to have a good Ashes – unperturbed by a Trevor Bayliss team talk in which he says, 'I've got just one word today I want you all to remember', before pausing, scratching his head and saying, 'I've forgotten what it is now.' I manage only four overs in the first Ashes Test at Edgbaston though before a calf injury rules me out. I try to bat the next innings to help the team but end up damaging it more while taking off for a run. I will play no further part than half a morning's cricket in the entire series. The media and papers are awash with it being the end of my career – that there is every chance I will never play for England again. I get